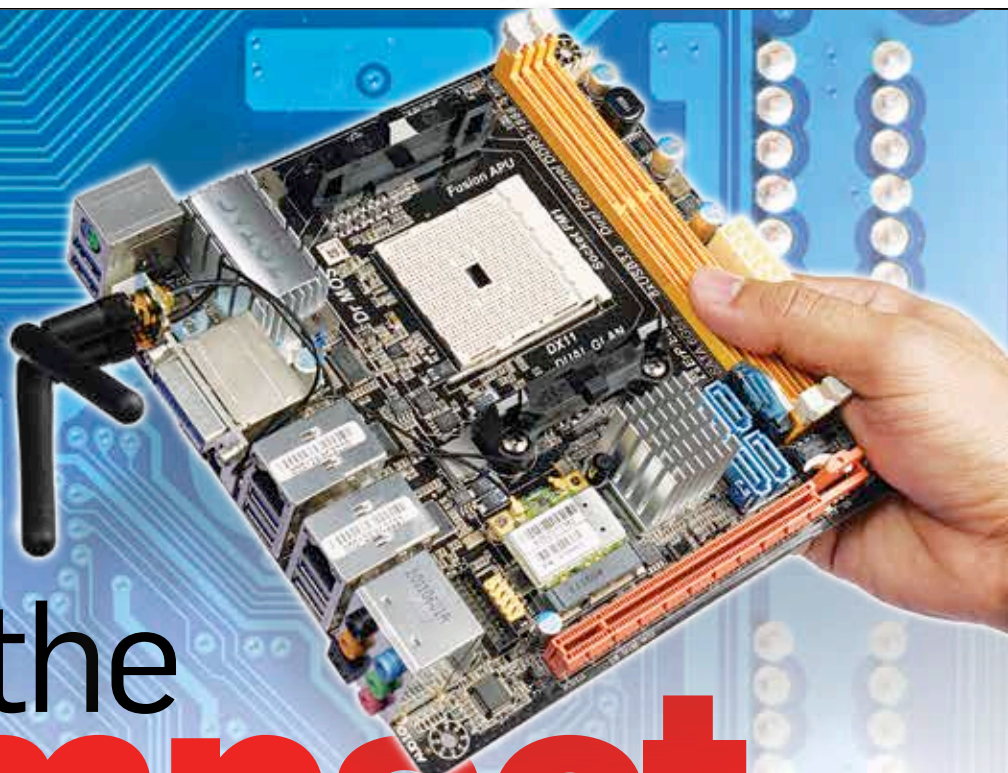


This month we look into the new phenomenon of Phone & Tablet hybrids - Phablets. Check out who won this round

We've tested plenty of new products including a printer that houses a router



For the Compact system builder...

Want a powerful system, but don't have enough space for a mid-tower cabinet? With a mini-ITX board, you can have a rig which does much more than a mere HTPC. We feature 13 boards in this shoot-out using top Intel and AMD processors

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In the November 2012 issue, we had tested mini-ITX boards with on-board processors and had promised to cover the non-processor sporting boards soon. This month we have covered the other end of the mini-ITX board spectrum. This segment is slowly but surely catching on, what with a lot of motherboard makers having a healthy

number of mini-ITX boards without processors in their portfolio. It makes sense specially in a country like ours, where not everyone has ample space to house a mid-tower or full-tower cabinet.

The main idea behind building a mini-ITX rig is to save on space, but at the same time get a powerful PC. Also with processors these days coming with a lower TDP than their predecessors around three-years back, it makes for a power-efficient system. With

mini-ITX boards sporting a Z77 chipset, it is not hard to make a decently powerful PC if you use the right components. For the purists who already have a power hungry high-end rig, but want more than a basic HTPC to complement their flat-screen TV, the mini-ITX boards with chipsets such as A75, H77 & H61 come to the rescue. Although in our test, we have used a 620W power supply, you do not really need a PSU rated that high if you are looking at a mainstream system build.

The Z77 boards

We got three Z77 boards, namely ASUS P8Z77-I Deluxe, ASRock Z77E-ITX and ZOTAC Z77-ITX. All three boards look quite different from each other thanks to different colour themes and board layouts.

The ASUS board layout is markedly different from the ASRock and ZOTAC boards. While on the former you have the chipset located between the PCIe x16 slot and the CPU socket, on the latter boards it is the CPU socket which lies between the